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Source: *Population and Development Review*, Vol. 30, No. 1 (Mar., 2004), pp. 25-56

Published by: [Population Council](#)

Stable URL: <http://www.jstor.org/stable/3401497>

Accessed: 17-04-2015 12:09 UTC

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When Does Religion Influence Fertility?

KEVIN MCQUILLAN

RELIGIOUS AFFILIATION as a determinant of demographic behavior was once at the forefront of demographic research, especially in studies of differential fertility. Particular attention was paid to the high fertility of Catholic populations in countries such as the United States (Ryder and Westoff 1971; Whelpton et al. 1966). But with the changes that swept through Catholic communities in many industrialized societies in the wake of the Second Vatican Council, Catholic fertility patterns came to resemble more closely those of other major religious denominations.¹ Westoff and Jones (1979) succinctly captured this change in the title of their article on the end of Catholic fertility. Not surprisingly, with the narrowing of fertility differences among religious groups came a withering of interest among demographers in understanding the sources of religious influence on demographic behavior.

Several recent developments in the field would seem to justify renewed interest in this old question. The empirical findings of the Princeton studies of the decline of fertility in Europe helped touch off a wave of interest in ascertaining how cultural beliefs and practices, including religious ones, influenced the fertility transitions in Europe and elsewhere (Anderson 1986; Gauvreau and Gossage 1997; Lesthaeghe and Wilson 1986; McQuillan 1999). More recently, this concern has extended to attempts to account for variation in the pace of the second demographic transition (Lesthaeghe and Neels 2002). Another source of interest in religion centers on fertility patterns in the Muslim world. Countries with large Muslim populations have been generally slower to experience fertility decline, and they figure prominently among the shrinking number of societies that continue to experience high rates of fertility (Caldwell 2001; United Nations 2003). Yet considerable disagreement surrounds the role Islam plays in the fertility patterns of these societies (Goldscheider 1999; Jejeebhoy and Sathar 2001; Morgan et al. 2002; Obermeyer 1992), reflecting, in part, the difficulty demographers have had in conceptualizing the influence of religion on demographic behavior. It thus seems opportune to revisit the question of religion and fertility in the light of a generation of new theoretical and empirical work.

Theoretical approaches to religion

The starting point for addressing the role of religion is the classic analysis by Calvin Goldscheider (1971), whose ideas still represent the point of departure in studies of religious differences in demographic behavior (Agadjanian 2001; Knodel et al. 1999). Goldscheider focused on fertility and critically assessed past approaches to understanding the role of religion while adding several ideas of his own, ideas that have proven influential in subsequent empirical research. He argued that attempts to explain the influence of religion commonly relied on one of two arguments. The first, which he labeled the “characteristics approach,” maintained that the association between religious affiliation and fertility was often spurious. The higher fertility of certain religious groups could be accounted for by the groups’ socioeconomic characteristics. Thus, controlling for such variables as education, income, and place of residence would reveal that the role of religion was apparent rather than real. As groups came to resemble one another on these dimensions, religious differentials in fertility would begin to disappear. But what if the association between religious affiliation and fertility persists even after taking account of the groups’ differing socioeconomic profiles? In that case, Goldscheider suggested, demographers would resort to a second approach that he called the “particularized theology” hypothesis. The essence of this perspective was that the demographic behavior under investigation—almost invariably, the higher fertility of a religious group—could be accounted for by the teachings of the denomination on questions related to childbearing. Thus, for example, the higher fertility of American Catholics was seen as a consequence of Church teachings that forbade Catholics to use artificial means of contraception.

Goldscheider was rightly critical of the particularized theology approach, describing it as “superficial” and “inadequate” (1971: 293). In his 1971 book and in subsequent work (Goldscheider and Mosher 1991; Goldscheider 1999), he suggested that two other lines of inquiry were likely to be more fruitful in understanding religion’s role in influencing demographic behavior. In the first instance, he urged demographers to expand their view of religion beyond specific teachings related to fertility control and to include “the total content of that social organization, of which the particular theology is but one part and often not the most significant” (1971: 274). In his more recent empirical work, which has examined the fertility patterns of religious groups in Israel, Goldscheider has directed attention to what he terms “broadly based norms of family control and gender relationships” (1999: 312).

In addition to a broader examination of the social organization of religious groups, Goldscheider (1971: 270–298) also argued for attention to the social status of the religious communities being studied. In particular,

he suggested that minority-group status might play an important role in shaping the demographic patterns of a religious or ethnic group. Drawing mostly on social psychological literature from the 1950s and 1960s, he argued that minority groups often face barriers to full social and economic integration into the dominant society, and that one way to limit the effect of these barriers to achievement was to reduce fertility. To be sure, this explanation would not cover all minority groups. Those groups that preferred separation from the larger society or that were committed to norms emphasizing large families or prohibiting fertility control might well exhibit fertility rates higher than those of the majority. In general, though, he expected that minority groups would be characterized by fertility rates below those of the society in which they were located.

Although more than 30 years have passed since Goldscheider's initial work in this area, the framework he proposed and later elaborated still provides a good foundation for addressing the role of religion in demography. In the following sections I attempt to advance the argument by further developing his ideas on the connections between religion and fertility and by drawing attention to two issues that received limited consideration in his work.

The sources of religious influence

Religion and values

It is hardly surprising that discussions of religion's influence on demographic behavior often begin with the role of values. More than most other social institutions, religions have elaborated moral codes that are meant to guide human behavior, and many of the great religious traditions have given special attention to issues of sexuality, the roles of men and women, and the place of the family in society.

In considering the role played by religious ideas, one needs to distinguish between two categories of values: relatively specific norms or rules that seek to regulate behavior that is directly connected to the proximate determinants of fertility, and broader values or principles whose effect on fertility is indirect. The first category consists of the teachings that Goldscheider identified as the concern of the "particularized theology" approach. Broadly speaking, specific rules designed to directly influence the proximate determinants of fertility are most typical of "the religions of the book": Judaism, Christianity, and Islam. Attention has focused on the teachings of these religions regarding the use of contraception and abortion, the most significant proximate determinants in many societies. All three religious traditions have supported restrictions on at least some of these practices. The Roman Catholic Church is undoubtedly the clearest, at least at the level of official doctrine, in forbidding most forms of contraception and any recourse

to abortion (Noonan 1986). Other Christian denominations have gradually moved toward more relaxed views on the issue of contraception, although a number maintain strong opposition to the practice of abortion (Smith 1983). A similar process has occurred in Judaism, with only Orthodox groups continuing to uphold restrictions on the practice of both sterilization and abortion (Kasher 1989; Simons 2003).

Islamic teaching on these questions has been marked by both controversy and evolution. But the absence of a clear religious hierarchy in the faith has meant there is no universally supported view on many of these issues. There is broad agreement in recent scholarship that Islam is generally supportive of family limitation, although opposition to abortion and to at least some forms of contraception, particularly sterilization, has been expressed by many Islamic leaders (Chamie 1981; Hoodfar and Assadpour 2000; Obermeyer 1992; Omran 1992; Simons 2003). A puzzling aspect of the debate concerns the difference between the teaching of Islamic leaders and scholars and the perceptions of the Muslim faithful. While analyses of religious writings and even surveys of religious leaders (Underwood 2000) suggest general approval of fertility control, surveys in several Muslim populations nevertheless find that men and women frequently give religious reasons for not practicing contraception (Caldwell and Barkat-e-Khuda 2000; Casterline et al. 2001). These findings point to the importance of examining both the "official" positions of a faith on such issues as contraception and the perceptions of those teachings among the faithful.

The concern with formulating moral directives regarding sexuality and procreation in these three traditions contrasts with the approach of the major Asian religions. While there is a rich tradition of ethical analysis in religions such as Buddhism and Hinduism, these faiths have not developed the formal, often hierarchical structures that characterize the scripture-based religions, nor have they attempted to articulate codes of conduct that serve as religious law for adherents. Rather, the ethical reflections have been seen as advice to followers of the faiths, who are nevertheless considered responsible for their own conduct. Leading thinkers in the Hindu and Buddhist traditions have expressed concern about practices in the area of reproduction, especially regarding abortion (Crawford 1989; Premasiri 1989; Simons 2003), but this has not led to explicit rules forbidding recourse to abortion nor to any sense that those who seek or perform abortions should face punishment. As a result, the major Asian religions imposed little if any constraint on the rapid diffusion of contraception and abortion once the motivation to control fertility spread through Asian populations (Knodel et al. 1987: 163).

While attention to religiously based rules that influence fertility understandably focuses primarily on issues of contraception and abortion, it is also true that many religions have articulated other guidelines that have

the potential to increase or limit fertility rates. Several pertinent examples may be briefly cited to illustrate the point. One involves rules governing entry into sexual unions. Constraints on age of entry into unions, number of spouses, and entry into subsequent unions after divorce or widowhood have been typical of many religious traditions—again, especially religions of the book. A second, related issue involves prohibitions by many religions of sexual activity outside of officially recognized unions. The importance of religiosity as a predictor of entry into cohabitation and nonmarital child-bearing underlines the potential significance of these teachings even in modern, Western societies (Thornton et al. 1992; Wu 2000). A third, less frequently discussed example involves issues of sexuality within marriage. A number of religions have elaborated rules affecting the timing and frequency of sexual relations between spouses. Many African religious traditions have promoted long periods of postpartum abstinence (Schoenmaeckers et al. 1981). A lesser-known example involves Catholic teaching on the “marital debt”—the obligation of spouses not to deny sexual gratification to their partner. As Hull (1996: 12) points out, this was one of the few elements of Catholic theology that might be seen as promoting sexual relations, and one that was also surprisingly egalitarian in insisting that the debt was to be honored by both husbands and wives.² It is not implausible that such beliefs were associated with the shorter birth intervals found in a number of Catholic populations of the past (Knodel 1988; McQuillan 1999).

Specific norms that impinge directly on the determinants of fertility are undoubtedly important, but they do not exhaust the ideological element of the religious influence in demography. In his critique of the particularistic theology approach, Goldscheider urged demographers to attend to the broader sociocultural messages associated with religious faiths and the potential influence these messages might have on fertility. Two broad classes of potential influences are often cited in the literature. One set includes values that speak directly to issues of fertility, although they do not involve specific rules about practices of fertility regulation. Mormon teachings on this topic are an especially good illustration. Although the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints has no particular rules regarding contraception, the philosophy of the Church is clearly pronatalist (Heaton 1986). In part, this reflects Mormon theology. Mormons believe that the plan of salvation can only be accomplished when all “worthy spirits” who have yet to be born come to experience life on earth. It is the duty of Mormons to help bring this to pass (Bean et al. 1990: 61). This theological rationale is complemented by the Church’s teaching on the central role of the family in the religious community. The married state is considered appropriate for all, including Church leaders, and large families are lauded as a sign of faithfulness to Church teachings. As Bean et al. (1990) point out, despite the absence of rules prohibiting the use of contraception, the strong and con-

sistent message of the Church favoring high fertility has been associated with a fertility rate that typically exceeds that of other religious groups in the same society (Heaton 1986; Thornton 1979).

There is some evidence that Islam has exercised a similar influence in parts of the developing world, particularly where Muslim populations are in the minority (Morgan et al. 2002). Emphasis on the importance of the family and a positive evaluation of large families may favor higher fertility and lead men and women to believe that the practice of family limitation is contrary to their religious beliefs.

Another example concerns religious beliefs related to the duties owed to one's ancestors. A number of faiths in both Asia and Africa see the obligations of the living to their ancestors as an important religious duty. Caldwell and Caldwell (1987) claim that, in many traditional African religions, bearing large numbers of children fulfills one's duty to ancestors and serves as a sign that those who produce children have been specially favored. Particular social opprobrium is attached to infertility and sterility, which are viewed as punishments inflicted by the ancestors or gods on evil-doers. Because women would most commonly be blamed for the failure to produce children, mothers might derive particular status from giving birth to a large number of offspring.³

A second class of religious values addresses broader issues of social organization that may ultimately affect rates of fertility. Goldscheider (1999) draws attention to a significant example: religious teachings on the appropriate roles for men and women. Examining the case of Arabs living in Israel, he argues that the group's high fertility rate does not reflect specific teachings related to contraception but rather Muslim views on the nature of familial relationships and the segregated roles of women. The lack of access to economic opportunities outside the family increases the dependence of women on male relatives and places a premium on conformity to the ideal of woman as mother. Given the importance of the family and the value attached to large families, women face strong pressure from relatives and the larger community to bear children.

While considerable evidence supports the proposition that greater autonomy for women is associated with lower fertility (Jejeebhoy 1995), the nature of the relationships among Islam, women's roles, and high fertility—what Obermeyer (1992) has termed the "fateful triangle"—is a focus of continuing debate. Obermeyer rejects the view that there is any necessary connection between Islam and women's autonomy. Moreover, recent empirical studies have found no evidence that Muslim women have less autonomy than women belonging to other religious groups in the same societies (Jejeebhoy and Sathar 2001; Morgan et al. 2002), and have questioned the link between autonomy and fertility in these populations (Amin and Lloyd 2002; Morgan et al. 2002). For our purposes, the debate on reli-

gion, women's autonomy, and fertility supports several conclusions. First, it is necessary to consider broadly the ways in which religious values may influence fertility. Second, it is essential to specify the pathways by which religious beliefs may affect fertility levels. In some cases, religion may influence the "supply side" of the equation by discouraging the use of contraception; in other instances, the impact may be on the "demand side" by increasing the number of children that couples desire. Third, analyses of a religious effect must seek to determine whether values that are widely held by members of a religious community are religious in origin or are shaped by other social factors. This requirement seems especially clear in the case of women's autonomy. Limitations on women's social roles can be found in most if not all societies. In some cases, religious leaders and institutions may play a direct role in promoting these limitations; in others, religion's role may be largely passive and consist of accepting a social order shaped by other social or political forces (Obermeyer 1992, 1994).

Analyses of the relationship between religion and fertility may have paid too much attention to the role of values. As Goldscheider and others have argued, the mere existence of religious teachings on such issues as sexuality, contraception, and the value of children does not inevitably lead to a particular pattern of fertility. Yet values are the essential starting point for any explanation of religious differences, because fertility differentials among religious groups that are not tied to variations in their religious beliefs are likely to be the result of differences in their socioeconomic situation, and thus do not constitute examples of a true religious effect. In that sense, values are a necessary though not sufficient basis for religion to serve as a determinant of fertility. The task for demographers is to identify the elements of religious teachings that may influence fertility and to trace the pathways that lead from these values to the proximate determinants of fertility.

The role of religious institutions

The wealth of empirical material that demographers have compiled on religious differences in fertility demonstrates that religious communities which share a common tradition of faith may yet differ significantly in their demographic histories. In the case of Catholicism, a religion that has developed a remarkably clear set of rules on a variety of issues with both direct and indirect implications for fertility, Catholic communities have been both leaders and laggards in the demographic transition. Areas of France, such as Normandy, generally regarded as the initiator of the fertility decline in Europe, had overwhelmingly Catholic populations (Coale and Treadway 1986). On the other hand, Catholicism has often been cited as a factor in delaying the decline of fertility in such places as Quebec and Ireland. In the case of Islam, religion has been associated with higher fertility and slower fertility

decline in such countries as Saudi Arabia, Pakistan, and Syria (Obermeyer 1992; Winckler 1999). By contrast, in Indonesia, Egypt, and even Iran, Islam has not proven to be an obstacle in the movement to low fertility (Aghajanian and Merhyar 1999; Hoodfar and Assadpour 2000; Obermeyer 1994).

What allows religious values to play a pivotal role in some settings but not in others? Religious values are most likely to matter when religious institutions have the means to communicate values to their members and to institute mechanisms to promote compliance and punish nonconformity. The institutional influence of religion can be felt at three levels: in the larger society, in the community, and in the life of the individual. In what follows, I first examine the example of Quebec, a setting in which the Catholic Church came to exercise unparalleled influence, to illustrate the significance of social institutions for translating religious values into an active force in the lives of the faithful. Then I consider the relevance of Quebec for other settings in which religious differentials in fertility have been documented.

Quebec. The Catholic Church was a dominant force in New France from the colony's establishment in 1608, and, despite conflict with agents of the French Crown over the limits of its role, the Church influenced the governance of the colony and established a network of institutions with both religious and secular ends (Ferretti 1999: 26–30). As is well known, the colony experienced dramatic demographic growth (Charbonneau et al. 1993). Although immigration from France was limited, the population increased from the original handful of settlers who arrived in the early seventeenth century to some 70,000 in 1763, when the Treaty of Paris transferred control of the territory to Britain (Charbonneau et al. 2000: 131). The arrival of the British saw notable changes in the population and social life of the colony. English-speaking Protestant officials, soldiers, and merchants came to Quebec and assumed leading positions in the political and economic structures of the colony. Although the rural areas of the province remained overwhelmingly French and Catholic, the small cities of Quebec and Montreal became ethnically and religiously mixed. The position of the Catholic Church was obviously affected by the change in sovereignty, yet church officials succeeded not only in holding onto their position of power but in expanding it. The new British colonial officials quickly came to view the Church as a useful ally in exercising control over the sometimes hostile local population (Hardy 1999: 215). As a result, the Church remained a dominant voice in the life the colony, while also continuing to operate a host of institutions including hospitals, orphanages, and a fledgling school system.

The influence of the Church among the French Catholic population, though formidable, was not uncontested. A small but growing indigenous

class of merchants and professionals came into conflict with both the British colonial authorities and the Church. These tensions grew through the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, culminating in an attempted rebellion against the colonial authorities in 1837, an uprising that, though quickly crushed, constituted a turning point for the colony and the Catholic Church. Colonial authorities might well have turned on the Church in retribution for its failure to head off the uprising; the populace might have rejected the Church for its failure to support their aspirations for change. In fact, however, the rebellion was an opening for the Church to consolidate its power. Civil leaders came to see the Church as their only safe conduit to the local population, while the loss of credibility suffered by the leaders of the rebellion led most of the population to accept the Church as the only force capable of defending their interests (Hardy 1999: 215).

Thus, in the period from 1840 to 1900, the Catholic Church in Quebec was able to extend its control and exercise unparalleled influence over many aspects of social life. Civil authorities allowed the Church extraordinary prerogative to handle issues that were the responsibility of the state in other modernizing societies. For example, the Church continued to handle the registration of births, marriages, and deaths. The rudimentary health care system was dominated by institutions established and run by religious orders. Perhaps most importantly, the Catholic Church benefited from almost complete control over the education of Catholics (Ferretti 1999; Hamelin and Gagnon 1984; Voisine 1971). The developing school system, though publicly supported, was explicitly confessional in nature. The schools in which Catholics were taught were overseen by a committee on which the Catholic bishops held half of the seats. Sympathetic laymen, appointed by the government, generally deferred to the bishops on crucial matters, ensuring that the Church exercised firm control over primary and secondary education (Linteau et al. 1983: 207). In response to growing demand for higher education, the Church established and ran a system of “classical colleges” in which theological studies occupied a predominant position, while the sole French-language university in Quebec until the late nineteenth century was operated under a Vatican charter (Ferretti 1999: 77–79).

The enormous institutional power that the Catholic Church had acquired in nineteenth-century Quebec made it the predominant force in the communities in which the faithful lived. As settlement spread across the territory, the Church established a network of parishes that allowed it to remain close to the population. Local parishes were, of course, first and foremost the setting for liturgical events. Sunday Mass drew all members of the community together and provided the critical forum for priests to present the Church’s view of the world to the faithful (Moreux 1969). The sermon delivered at Mass was an opportunity for the clergy to convey the teachings of the Church, including its view on sexuality (Hubert 2002: 56). But the

ritual of Sunday Mass entailed more than an opportunity for instruction. In nearly homogeneous settings where attendance was mandatory, the event took on great symbolic importance. The convention in Quebec was for families to own a pew in the Church, for which they paid an annual stipend. The pews nearest the altar were especially sought after and often monopolized by those of higher prestige (Hubert 2002: 40–41). Thus one's position in the Church reflected one's status in the community and was on display weekly as well as at the great celebrations of the year. The good name of a family was intimately linked to its status within the parish community. Ollivier Hubert described the situation in rural Quebec in the eighteenth century: "Attendance at Sunday Mass exposed the family to the persistent scrutiny of other families, which acted as a powerfully constraining form of social control" (Hubert 2002: 44).

The Church extended its control over ceremonial occasions beyond the Sunday service, creating a host of other rituals that marked the important times of the year. The liturgical calendar was replete with holy days, festivals, and celebrations which drew the community together in a context that was explicitly religious. Threats to the community's health or prosperity, such as outbreaks of disease or inclement weather that threatened the harvest, were answered by special religious rituals intended to protect the society. Indeed, the Church was successful in exerting a near monopoly on the symbolic universe such that even secular community events invariably involved a religious dimension.

A second key element of the Church's strategy at the community level involved creating or seeking control of groups that had other than purely religious functions. The Catholic Church sought to establish groups for all members of the community, often organized along lines of age and sex (Châtellier 1989; Ferretti 1992). The groups became important social institutions, sometimes the only organizations to which people belonged. Their activities were most often a mix of the religious and the secular and might serve as the vehicle through which individuals participated in religious and secular ceremonies. Processions organized to celebrate holidays or community events grouped people according to their membership in these associations. The organizations offered one of the few opportunities for people to hold positions of power and influence within the local community. But holding such a position entailed conformity to the religious principles on which the groups were founded. Moreover, occupying these positions left one's life open to particular scrutiny by the clergy, who often served as patrons of the organization and frequently exercised implicit control over the selection of leaders.

The spread of schooling in many Catholic societies during the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries provided a key challenge for Church authorities. I described already how the Church moved at the political level

to gain control over the educational system. At the local level there was also a determined effort to monitor activities in the classroom; crucial in this regard was control over school personnel. With the tremendous growth of vocations that occurred in nineteenth-century Quebec, it became possible to place nuns and priests in many of the schools of the province. While only 4 percent of the school teachers in the fledgling system that existed in 1836 were religious personnel, by 1900 43 percent of teachers were members of religious orders (Voisine 1971: 44).

The dense web of organizational structures that the Church sought to create embedded individuals in a setting where religious influences abounded, and where decisions about a course of action were almost inevitably shaped by religious concerns (Ferretti 1992). The full effect of these structures could be felt by individuals in their everyday lives, for the Church was in a position to bestow rewards that upheld people's sense of honor, or to withhold rewards and inflict punishments that undermined their positions in the local community. One of the most powerful strategies for accomplishing this was the Church's successful monopoly of the ceremonies that marked the turning points in life. The basic acts of demography—birth, marriage, and death—are celebrated or commemorated in all societies by public rituals. In Catholicism, the Church not only administered religious rites—sacraments—that people expected to take part in, but successfully defined participation in the religious rituals as necessary for acceptance within the community and, of course, for salvation in the world to come. Baptism was the essential rite of entrance into the community of the faithful. Marriage before a priest under the rules of the Church was the only legitimate path to respectable family life. A Church funeral followed by burial in consecrated grounds was essential to ensure passage to peace in the life to come and to comfort loved ones left behind. Thus, to deny access to these rites precluded full participation in the community and thereby threatened the honor of individuals and families.

In nineteenth-century Quebec, the Church made sparing but effective use of this power. Although children were rarely denied baptism, those born to cohabiting couples could receive baptism only with the permission of the bishop (Lemieux 1989: 261). Those who hoped to play the part of godparent had to show evidence of having completed their Easter duty of confession and communion (Lemieux 1989: 259). Marriage in the Church, on the other hand, required extensive preparation and was often forbidden to those who violated Church rules, especially if there was evidence of premarital cohabitation (Gagnon 1993). Perhaps the most contested cases involved the denial of Christian burial. A survey of pastors revealed relatively few cases in which deceased Catholics were denied a Church funeral and burial in a Catholic cemetery (Gagnon 1987). But religious authorities were prepared to take this dramatic step when they believed that Church law had been

flaunted. The most famous case that occurred in nineteenth-century Quebec is also an especially instructive one (Clark 1971). Joseph Guibord belonged to a liberal political group, the *Institut Canadien*, membership in which had been expressly forbidden to Catholics by the bishop. Guibord, on his deathbed, refused to renounce his membership in the group and was denied a Catholic funeral. Moreover, when his family attempted to bury him in the family-owned plot in the Catholic cemetery, the Church was successful in convincing the civil authorities to forcibly prevent the interment (Gagnon 1987: 94–95). The case illustrates the wide-ranging influence of Church leaders in society and their ability and willingness to use their power over religious rituals to discipline those who violated their teachings.

The sacrament of confession was an especially important means of social control exercised by the Catholic Church (Tentler 1977). The nature of confession obliged the faithful to admit to violations of Church law and permitted confessors to question penitents who might not be entirely forthcoming about their failings. If sins were judged to be particularly serious or if confessors had doubts about the sincerity of the penitents' sorrow and resolve to amend their ways, the priest might withhold absolution or reserve the case for the attention of the bishop. Particular attention was paid to sins of a sexual nature, including those that involved the use of contraception (Gagnon 1999: 19), a sin for which absolution was sometimes withheld (Baillargeon 1999: 72–73). For our purposes, the special importance of confession was that, though a private act in which the priest was bound to secrecy, it was the essential step to participation in other activities that were public. To be refused absolution barred one from the other sacraments of the Church. Those left behind in the pew at Easter while others went forward to receive the Eucharist were exposed to public judgment and condemnation by friends and neighbors. Of course, those who violated religious precepts might simply avoid confession altogether, seek absolution elsewhere, or be sparing in the details of their actions. To be sure, this undoubtedly occurred, but the Church in Quebec worked hard to make it as difficult as possible. Church authorities demanded that penitents seek absolution from a parish priest who knew them and their personal history or obtain his permission to confess elsewhere (Gagnon 1990: 99). Failure to obtain absolution closed the door to participation in other Church rituals. For French Canadians prior to 1960, to be barred from active involvement in the Church had both practical and emotional consequences. Personal honor and the reputation of one's family would be called into question. Participation in the many organizations the Church operated or controlled would be affected. Indeed, especially in smaller communities, to be publicly identified as a "bad Catholic" might entail economic disadvantage and social exclusion, as well as the emotional costs associated with a marginal status in a society in which religion played such a vital role.

Given the web of structures that influenced so much of the setting in which people conducted their daily lives, it is not surprising that religious participation among the French-Catholic population reached very high levels. A study of the largely rural region of Trois-Rivières showed that the proportion of Catholics receiving Communion at Easter rose from already high levels around 1850 to near universal acceptance by 1875 (Hardy 1999: 135). Reflecting on these data, Hardy (1994: 197) remarks: "The religious and lay elites, through their collaboration, had succeeded in inculcating...a model of conduct that no one could transgress without suffering public disapproval." And even in the growing city of Montreal, with its religiously mixed population and greater opportunity for avoiding public or clerical censure, religious participation increased markedly in the latter half of the nineteenth century. More faithful observance of Easter duty and greater lay participation in parish associations pointed toward the larger role played by religion in the lives of ordinary people (Rousseau 1995: 237). But perhaps the most striking confirmation of the Church's growing influence in Quebec society was the steady increase in the number of vocations to the religious life. Even though the population was growing rapidly, the ratio of members to priests fell from one priest per 1,185 faithful in 1840 to one per 680 by 1900, and one per 576 in 1931, undoubtedly making Quebec one of the most clericalized societies in the world (Ferretti 1999: 65, 102).

The dominant role played by the Catholic Church in Quebec and the near universal participation of the francophone population in the rites of the faith were conducive to the persistence of a demographic pattern consistent with Catholic teaching on matters of sexuality and the family. Although the province experienced significant industrialization and urbanization during the second half of the nineteenth century, marital fertility in Quebec remained high, with the first signs of fertility decline appearing only near the turn of the century (Gauvreau and Gossage 1997; Gossage and Gauvreau 2000). McInnis (2000: 410) estimates an index of marital fertility I_g of .80 for the province in 1891,⁴ and one must remember that the province's population included a significant English Protestant minority among whom fertility control had clearly spread (Olson and Thornton 1991, 1992).

The twentieth century brought evidence of greater control over fertility, particularly in the cities. Increasing concern about the costs of raising a large family in an urban environment began to be heard through the popular media. Yet the estimated total fertility rate for the province in 1911 was 5.4 births per woman (Gauvreau and Gossage 1997: 478). Qualitative data obtained from interviews with women who bore their children in the 1920s and 1930s suggest that they were keenly aware of the Catholic view of contraception and reluctant to disobey those teachings. The first efforts

at fertility control relied largely on abstinence and the rhythm method, the only techniques approved by the Catholic Church. Withdrawal was practiced by a minority of couples, especially in the city of Montreal, but was largely unknown in other regions of the province. In their assessment of these interviews, Gauvreau and Gossage (1997) suggest that the explicitly pronatalist and anti-contraceptive message of religious authorities was one key aspect of the Church's influence. A second was Catholic teaching on the proper role of a wife and her duty to obey her husband. A number of the women interviewed reported little or no communication with their husbands over issues of sexual relations or contraception. This led some to believe they had no choice but to have sex when their husbands demanded and face the consequences. As one respondent they quote put it: "You did your duty and that was all" (Gauvreau and Gossage 1997: 507). To be sure, some of the women interviewed voiced concern over their situation and skepticism concerning the position of the Church on matters of sexual relations and contraception. However, data from a survey of Quebec women conducted in 1971 show that only 19 percent of women born between 1906 and 1910 reported ever having practiced contraception. There seems little doubt that the powerful role played by the Catholic Church in Quebec was one factor impeding the spread of fertility control. Moreover, conformity to Catholic teaching on contraception was matched by control over sexual relations outside marriage. Hardy (2001) has shown that the proportion of premarital conceptions in the region of Trois-Rivières remained low right up until the end of the nineteenth century. Data on births outside marriage even for the city of Montreal suggest that Catholic teaching on nonmarital sexual relations was widely observed well into the twentieth century.

The Quebec case shows convincingly the salience of the institutional dimension of religion in shaping individual behavior. The persistence of high marital fertility and the limited use of contraceptive methods opposed by the Catholic Church, despite far-reaching economic and social change that encouraged the spread of fertility control in other societies, illustrate religion's potential to influence the course of demographic change. But is the Quebec example, clearly extraordinary in the scope of religious influence on society, useful for understanding the role of religion in other settings?

Ireland. An obvious parallel to the Quebec case is the experience of Ireland. Recent research has qualified the traditional picture of Ireland as a country with late marriage and unrestrained marital fertility, the latter a consequence of devout Catholicism (Guinnane 1997; Ó Gráda 1991). Nevertheless, even revised versions of Ireland's demographic history point to very high rates of marital fertility in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries and a very slow transition to controlled fertility. Ó Gráda (1991: 536)

estimates an I_g of .825 for 1881, declining to just .760 in 1911, a much higher figure than found in countries such as England, Germany, and Italy at those dates (Coale and Treadway 1986). Moreover, Ó Gráda's analysis of inter-county variation in marital fertility rates identifies the proportion Catholic as a strong correlate of marital fertility, a relationship that does not disappear when other social characteristics such as the level of industrialization or literacy are controlled. High fertility among the Catholics of Ireland persisted well into the twentieth century. Kennedy (1973: 175) gathered data on marital fertility for the early 1960s, showing Ireland to have had easily the highest rate in Europe. Data from the 1990s confirm that fertility among Catholics in the North and South of Ireland has been declining but still remains significantly above the level in other parts of Europe and above the rates for other religious groups in both Northern Ireland and the Republic (Ó Gráda and Walsh 1995). New research has modified the traditional picture of Ireland's demographic past and suggests that the country experienced some fertility decline at an earlier date than had been assumed. At the same time, as Ó Gráda aptly concludes: "If recent historiography has exaggerated Ireland's failure to join in the fertility transition, we must also be careful not to make exaggerated claims in the other direction" (1991: 545).

Ireland's high rate of marital fertility was accompanied by a low rate of extramarital childbearing. Despite a pattern of late marriage and an extraordinarily high level of permanent celibacy, the nonmarital fertility rate in Ireland remained low (Kennedy 1973: 174). Guinnane (1997) suggests that official figures may underestimate the true level of illegitimacy since children born out of wedlock in rural areas may have been falsely recorded as belonging to the young woman's parents. Yet, even assuming some degree of under-reporting, there is little doubt that nonmarital births were surprisingly few in a setting in which so many young people remained unmarried until a late age.

The role of religion in Ireland's distinctive demographic history has been called into question by some of the leading students of the country. Kennedy (1973), in his pioneering work, and, more recently, Guinnane (1997) have contended that economic factors played the leading role in supporting the Irish demographic model of late marriage and high marital fertility. Their work has been a useful corrective to simplistic explanations that see the Irish case as revealing a "priest-ridden" people blindly following the dictates of their religion. In their efforts to counterbalance this older view, however, they risk erring in the other direction. While there were distinctive aspects of Ireland's economic development, particularly the growing reliance on pasture agriculture and the country's low degree of industrialization, the Irish experience was not so different from that in other parts of Europe that these factors alone would account for the limited spread of fertility control until well into the twentieth century. As David Miller (1973: 1) has succinctly put it, "Religion

was the central fact of Irish life," and undoubtedly an importance influence on its demographic development.

At first glance, the Irish experience presents a number of striking similarities to the case of Quebec. Both had overwhelmingly Catholic populations who lived for a long period in a colonial or quasi-colonial status under a sovereign of a different faith. In both cases, too, the civil elite came to recognize the Catholic Church as an important political force, one that was to be treated with deference for fear of alienating the local population. The autonomy granted to the Church in Quebec was undoubtedly greater than was true in Ireland. And the local population in Quebec gained greater control over their political destiny at an earlier point in time with the changes that accompanied the founding of Canada in 1867, while the ability of Irish leaders to exercise effective control remained limited prior to the founding of the Irish Free State in 1922. Nevertheless, at the political level, the experiences of the two countries and the role of the Catholic Church were similar in several ways.

As in Quebec, the Catholic Church emerged as a dominant institution in Ireland. In the rural villages of Ireland, "the Church was the focus of the entire social life of the community" (Miller 1973: 1). Also as in Quebec, the Church created a web of organizations that offered a place for people of all statuses. Groups for men, women, and youth played an important role in the lives of individuals and the community. The Church provided an array of social services, limited though they were, including initiatives in health and social welfare. And perhaps most importantly, the Church led a long-running campaign to bolster its control over education. In contrast to the situation in Quebec, where the province gained control over the system of education in 1867 and created a confessional model of education, Ireland maintained a public, nondenominational school system. Yet the demographic characteristics of the country meant that, in practice, most Catholic children attended schools that were entirely or in large majority Catholic. According to Hoppen (1999: 170), by 1870 half of all Catholic children went to schools that were 100 percent Catholic. Moreover, Church officials gradually attained great influence over the operation of the system, including control over the hiring of teachers. Hoppen concludes that "Catholic and Presbyterian authorities proved themselves brilliantly successful in turning what was in theory a non-sectarian state-supported enterprise into one which eventually provided denominational schools at the taxpayers' expense" (1999: 170). The influence of Church leaders in Ireland only grew in the years ahead. New industrial schools were set up under clerical control, and the Church extended its hold over higher education and teacher training. With the founding of the Republic of Ireland in 1922, the Catholic Church formalized its control over education, though the change meant less than might have been expected given the tremendous power it had already acquired in the late decades of the Union.

The Church also made ever greater efforts to guide the consciences of its followers in matters related to the family and sexuality. Hoppen (1999) speaks of the Church's promotion of an ideology of "rural anti-materialism," a blend of ideas that glorified the large farm family and showered special praise on women's roles as wife and mother. The celebration of this positive image of the family was accompanied by increasingly strident critiques of "immorality" in sexual matters, a campaign that reached its high point under the Republic with the enactment of laws outlawing divorce and the sale of contraceptives. Indeed, during the first decades of the new Republic the Catholic Church's institutional power in Irish society reached its apex.

Along with these developments at the political and institutional level, Irish Catholics also experienced what has been termed a "devotional revolution" (Larkin 1972), similar in many ways to that which occurred in Quebec. Despite the popular stereotype of the Irish as devout Catholics, many Irish historians have concluded that before the mid-nineteenth century, the Catholic Church was weakly organized and large numbers of people were indifferent to the faith. Priests had little training, the faith was a mixture of official Catholicism and popular traditions, and services were often poorly attended. However, the period following the Famine of 1845–48 saw many of the same changes that had taken place in nineteenth-century Quebec. Attendance levels at Mass rose significantly and membership in religious organizations boomed as well. As in Quebec, perhaps the best quantitative indicator of the change was the rise in the number of vocations to the priesthood and sisterhood. Although the overall population was falling as a result of the after-effects of the Famine and the very high levels of emigration, the number of priests increased in the second half of the century, causing the ratio of parishioners to priests to fall from one per 2,773 in 1845 to one per 1,126 in 1901. During the same period, the number of women who entered religious life grew sharply, from just 1,500 around 1850 to over 8,000 at the turn of the century (Hoppen 1999: 50).

As was true in Quebec, political developments in Ireland provided an opening for the Catholic Church to extend its influence in Irish society. Its leaders followed a carefully crafted strategy that allowed the Church a significant role in many of the institutions of the country. Moreover, the Church used its position as a *de facto* leader of the Catholic population in its struggle with English authorities to build a stronger bond of attachment to the institution among its followers. In this setting, the Catholic Church was able to promote more effectively its teachings on matters related to family life and childbearing, thereby contributing to the persistence of high fertility among Ireland's Catholics well after fertility decline had taken root in other parts of western and northern Europe.

Islam. The growing acceptance in the West of the separation of civil and religious authority means that there are no present-day examples simi-

lar to the experiences of Quebec and Ireland in the past. This, however, is not true in the Muslim world. In several largely Muslim societies, Islam is a leading political and social force, and religious authorities exercise broad influence over their followers. What is striking in the case of Islam, however, is the variability in its message on key demographic questions. While Catholicism long spoke with one voice, even if the message was sometimes altered by local leaders, the lack of consensus in the Muslim world on a number of issues related to sexuality and childbearing has led to paradoxical results in societies where Islam is the dominant religion. In Saudi Arabia, Islamic influence has been associated with the persistence of high fertility. By contrast, in Iran, where Islamic influence in society has been far-reaching since the revolution of 1979, religious leaders and institutions have contributed to the legitimization of family planning programs that have led to a rapid decline in fertility (Hoodfar and Assadpour 2000).

The Iranian example is particularly instructive for understanding the interaction between religious teachings and the role played by religious institutions. As Hoodfar and Assadpour (2000: 20) explain, in the immediate postrevolutionary period religious leaders spearheaded opposition to family planning, which was portrayed as part of a Western plot to reduce the size and influence of the Muslim population. Their teachings, which contrasted with the generally positive view of family planning that had been advanced by religious leaders under the Shah, led to considerable confusion among the population. But those religious leaders who now also held positions of political leadership were soon faced with the need to solve many problems that were aggravated by the rapid growth of Iran's population. Moreover, there was considerable pressure from intellectuals, civil servants, and elements of the general population to support a policy that would make access to contraception easier and slow the rate of population growth. This pressure led to a widespread debate in which religious leaders played an important part and in turn forged a consensus that the practice of family planning was, under most circumstances, consistent with the teachings of Islam. Perhaps most importantly, once consensus had been achieved, it became possible for state authorities to use the institutions of the faith to promote contraceptive use. The vast network of mosques, which extended to even the most remote villages, was employed to spread the details of the officially sponsored population program. Local religious leaders were especially effective in presenting the message in a way that would be acceptable to poorer, less-educated Iranians who might have resisted the advice had it been offered by government officials. Thus, in spite of an environment that still involves substantial restrictions on the social roles open to women, restrictions that are at least partially religiously based, religious leaders have made a substantial contribution to Iran's rapid decline in fertility, which saw the total fertility rate fall from 5.6 in 1986 to 3.3 in 1995 (Hoodfar and

Assadpour 2000: 32). Iran's experience underlines the need for demographers to attend both to the content of religious beliefs and to the willingness and ability of religious leaders and institutions to promote compliance with those teachings among their followers.

American Catholics. The examples discussed so far in this section deal with situations in which one religion played a dominant role in society. But can religion shape demographic behavior in settings where there is religious pluralism and where a particular religious denomination may lack support from civil institutions or perhaps even face opposition? A particular religious faith may play a key role in such societies if it is successful in building a network of institutions that organize vital elements of the lives of its followers. To illustrate this point, I will briefly discuss three situations in which evidence suggests that the fertility pattern of a particular religious group differed significantly from those of other groups in the same society.

One of the more interesting examples, and one that was the basis for much early theorizing on the role of religion in influencing demographic behavior, is the case of Catholics in the United States. Some of the earliest fertility surveys documented the significantly higher fertility of Catholic Americans and emphasized that this higher fertility was not simply a consequence of different socioeconomic characteristics (Whelpton et al. 1966). Especially striking was the finding that the gap between Protestants and Catholics was often largest among the best-educated women (Westoff and Potvin 1967). How did Catholicism come to matter so much in a society that emphasized the separation of church and state, and in which great pressure toward assimilation was common? Part of the answer lies in the Catholic Church's success in making itself a central part of the communities that immigrant groups established in their new country. Dolan (1987, 2002) has shown how successive waves of immigrants transformed the American Catholic community. Before about 1820, the Catholic community of the United States was small, overwhelmingly English-speaking, and reasonably well integrated into the larger society. But growing European immigration after this date gave the Catholic community a more foreign face in American society. The early waves of Irish and German Catholics were followed by migrants from southern and eastern Europe as well as by those who arrived from Mexico. Most immigrants settled in urban areas and, as they did so, they often built largely homogeneous ethnic enclaves. Religion and ethnicity were intimately linked as these new communities stood apart from the dominant Anglo-Protestant population. On the one hand, Catholic immigrants experienced a measure of discrimination and exclusion, while on the other hand many of the groups sought to create social institutions that would permit them to preserve their ethnic and linguistic heritage.

In these ethnic-group communities, the Catholic Church played a critical role. The parish stood at the center of the community's social and symbolic life. Most of the immigrant groups brought with them religious traditions they sought to continue in their new land (Sterne 2000). Observance of feast days to honor patron saints, processions, and other examples of piety and devotion drew together the members of ethnic communities in a religious setting. The parishes established a variety of organizations that served both religious and secular functions. Faced with the problems of establishing themselves in this new setting, many immigrants looked to family and Church to provide assistance. Perhaps of greatest importance was the movement to build a distinctively Catholic system of education. The evolution of the system was complex and its success varied among groups and across regions (Dolan 1987). Yet it became a medium for the transmission of religious values to successive generations of American Catholics. Typically located in close proximity to the parish, the schools allowed ample opportunity for the parish priest to play a guiding role. And the growing importance of nuns and priests as teachers further extended the Church's role in education. With the expansion of higher education, Catholic colleges and universities spread across America to respond to the aspirations of the now well-established communities.

The educational system played a critical role in transmitting and reinforcing Catholic teachings. One topic that received great attention was the family. Indeed, contraception was seen both inside and outside the Catholic community as an issue that highlighted the difference in orientation between Catholics and the dominant Protestant majority. Some critics saw the Church's staunch opposition to the spread of birth control as evidence of a desire to impose its religious beliefs on society, while for Catholics themselves, fidelity to this increasingly inflexible teaching was seen as a true test of faith. Only in the aftermath of the Second Vatican Council, and the many accompanying social changes that occurred in American society, did Catholics in large numbers reject Church teaching on contraception and establish a pattern of fertility in line with the other major religious denominations.

Mormons. Catholics were not the only religious group in American society to develop strong institutional structures that helped to promote a distinctive demographic pattern. Among the most important other examples is the case of the Mormons. The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints was founded by Joseph Smith and a small group of followers in 1830. Its beliefs, some of which were highly controversial, quickly brought the group into conflict with other denominations and the larger society. After a tumultuous period of rapid growth and continuing conflict, as well as the death of its founder, the group moved westward, settling in the late 1840s in the area that would become the state of Utah. Mormons have experienced high

fertility and steady growth throughout their history (Thornton 1979). Data from the 1982 and 1988 National Survey of Family Growth indicate that the total fertility rate for Mormon women was 3.06, compared to a rate of 1.76 for all non-Hispanic white women (Althaus 1992). More recent data for the state of Utah suggest that fertility rates remain significantly above the national average. Moreover, the state had the lowest proportion of births to unmarried women and one of the lowest abortion rates in the country (U.S. Census Bureau 2001: 61, 65, and 72).

I noted above the religious principles of the Mormon faith that are consistent with high fertility. A strong commitment to a patriarchal model of the family, a belief that having children gives unborn spirits the opportunity to enjoy eternal life, and a rigorous set of moral teachings that reject extramarital sexuality and abortion are consistent with a demographic pattern that entails near universal marriage, relatively high marital fertility, and very low nonmarital fertility. These beliefs made a difference, in particular, because the Mormon Church was a powerful force in the lives of its members. One element of this influence, at least in the American case, was the geographical isolation of the faithful. The goal of the Mormon founders was to create a new society, a "city on the hill," where people's behavior would be guided by a social order based on religious principles. Both the early attempts at settlement in the American Midwest and the ultimately successful project in Utah involved the creation of homogeneous settlements that kept the larger society at a distance. As late as 1895, when Utah became a state, almost 90 percent of its population was Mormon. By 1975, 70 percent of the state's population still belonged to the Mormon Church (Poll 1978: 692–693), a figure that has changed little since then.

Undoubtedly more important than the tendency to live in relatively segregated communities was the influence of the Mormon Church on the organization of community and individual activity. In the early days of the Utah community, Church leaders directed virtually all aspects of community life (Leone 1979). As non-Mormons moved into the territory, this created intense conflict, not only with other settlers, but also with the federal government. In the face of great pressure from the federal government, the Mormon Church gradually accepted a reduced role in the territory, which involved sharing of political power with non-Mormons, the rejection of certain controversial beliefs, including polygamy, and the acceptance in principle of the separation of Church and state (Gottlieb and Wiley 1984: 49–51). Nevertheless, for Mormon followers the Church continued to play a dominant role in their lives. The Church built powerful institutions that tied believers closely to the organization. All men were encouraged to join the priesthood, a status that did not demand a full-time commitment to the ministry but did extend personal involvement in the faith (Leone 1979: 39). Separate organizations for women and youth encouraged participation that

went beyond weekly attendance at religious services (Leone 1979: 66). The commitment to tithing increased the stake that members held in the Church and endowed the organization with the means to build and support a substantial bureaucracy. A strong commitment to social service also drew large numbers of Church members into activities that, though not explicitly religious, engaged them in cooperative activities with fellow believers.

As was true with many other religious groups, Mormons placed a particularly high value on education. Early Church leaders believed strongly in the value of education and in the role of religion in schooling. Church strategy on educational issues shifted over time and between communities. In some cases, the Church attempted to influence the public school system, an approach that frequently led to complaints from non-Mormons (Alexander and Allen 1984: 111–113). More often, and increasingly over time, the Church opted to develop its own institutions to supplement public schooling while also creating explicitly denominational schools, such as Brigham Young University, to educate the faithful. This combination of pronatalist values and far-reaching institutional influence over Church members has produced a fertility rate among American Mormons that has been consistently higher than that of most other religious groups in the United States.

Europe. Finally, the role of religion in the European demographic transition should be alluded to. The Princeton studies pointed to the existence of religious differentials in several settings as exemplifying the influence of culture in demographic change (Anderson 1986). Lesthaeghe and colleagues (Lesthaeghe and Neels 2002; Lesthaeghe and Surkyn 1988) have identified persistent regional differences in demographic behavior, extending to the present day, that are correlated with differences in religious practice. Lesthaeghe argues, however, that the influence of religion is not captured by simple indicators of affiliation or religiosity. Rather, it was the role of the churches in the social and political environment that was crucial. Demographic change has been slowest in regions where the Catholic Church was involved in an ongoing ideological struggle with the forces of modernization and secularization. This situation often entailed conflict over control of the educational system and frequently led to the formation of political parties and labor unions that were associated with the Catholic Church and supported its position on social issues (Lesthaeghe and Wilson 1986; Stark and Finke 2000: 245). The stronger role of the Catholic Church in these regions supported resistance to secularization and delayed, though ultimately did not prevent, the onset of the first and second demographic transitions (Brown and Guinnane 2002).

The essential point of this part of the argument is that religious values, while important, are likely to play a critical role in shaping demographic behavior

only when religious authorities have at their disposal a menu of rewards and sanctions that will encourage the faithful to conform. This, in turn, is most apt to come about when churches are able both to build a network of religious institutions that play a formative role in the lives of members and to exercise influence over civil institutions in society as well. Such influence does not come about by chance. Religious leaders must mobilize the resources of their churches to advance their agenda. This often means cooperating with civil leaders. Sometimes this cooperation occurs because the Church is the only institution with the resources to carry out certain tasks such as education, health care, or service to the poor. At other times, as was true in the aftermath of the Reformation, civil leaders believe churches can provide valuable support to them and, in exchange, they are willing to grant greater powers to religious leaders in certain spheres of social life (Hsia 1989; Schilling 1988). The major lesson of the cases discussed above is that an understanding of religion's role requires attention to structures as well as values. This, in turn, requires understanding the social and political context within which religious institutions operate.

Religious identity

Institutional power may produce signs of conformity in situations where deviance brings severe punishment to offenders, but it may also encourage cynicism that leads to covert forms of resistance and outright rejection once the institution's power begins to weaken. However, where religious affiliation is widely accepted by the population as a key marker of who they are as a people, there is likely to be broader popular support for upholding the teachings of the faith and greater public pressure on rule-breakers to conform. This kind of voluntary identification with a religious faith is most common in situations where religion and nationalism blend together, and where religious identity distinguishes a people from other groups in the territory who are either competitors or oppressors (Stark and Finke 2000: 236–249). This line of thought, which flows from the works of Simmel (1955 [1908]) and Coser (1956), emphasizes the importance of social conflict in reinforcing the internal solidarity of groups. It helps us to understand the puzzling persistence of religious differentials in demographic behavior in a number of socio-historical settings.

Several of the examples discussed above in which Catholicism has been associated with higher fertility or a delayed fertility transition have been situations in which religion formed a critical part of a group's sense of identity and in which the Church played an important role in ongoing social or political conflict. This has been especially clear in settings where Catholics lived in a colonial or quasi-colonial situation. Ferretti (1999: 35), for example, has noted that among Catholic subjects of a foreign sovereign who professed a different religion, a merging of religious and national identity

and a larger role for the Church were common. In Quebec, the Catholic Church came to be seen as the only force capable of defending the interests of French Canadians against British colonial authorities. In Hardy's (1999: 154) view: "Catholicism...was an important element in the construction of the French Canadian identity. The first nationalist effort, which appeared at the beginning of the nineteenth century, considered the Church as a national institution and presented religion as a factor in the cohesion of the nation." During much of Quebec's history, the survival of the French language and, indeed, of French Canadians as a people was seen as inseparable from the destiny of the Church. In Ireland, Catholicism became intimately linked with the national struggle, especially during the height of the Church's influence in the late nineteenth century. Religious affiliation was a key basis of both support for and resistance to the drive for Home Rule and came increasingly to be the source of sectarian conflict. In this setting, religion became a "badge of nationality," and Catholic Church leaders emerged as "the only natural leaders in the rural community" (Miller 1973: 1). In Poland, as well, Catholicism formed an increasingly important part of national identity as Poles struggled to maintain their independence from both Orthodox Russia (and, later, an officially atheistic Soviet Union) and largely Protestant Germany. The Catholic Church became a center of resistance and a ferocious defender of Polish language and culture. To be a Polish patriot was to be a Catholic (Borkowski 1995: 4).⁵

A parallel process has been occurring in many parts of the world in which Islam has served as a force of resistance to the economic and cultural changes associated with globalization. In the Iranian revolution of 1979, Islam formed the ideological basis for the overthrow of the Shah and the rejection of the Western-style modernization that was associated with his regime. The Iranian case has seen the direct involvement of Islamic clerics in civic governance, an unusual development in light of Islamic teaching, which has supported a limited role for religious leaders in politics (Brown 2000: 177). This development has, at least in the short term, increased the influence of Islam on social and demographic behavior. In many other parts of the Muslim world, religion has formed the basis for a critique of existing social structures and has led to demands for a new social order based on Islamic values and laws. Whether this reflects an authentic Islamic influence or a situation in which political elites have drawn selectively on elements of Islamic tradition is a matter of debate (Obermeyer 1994). There is no disputing the fact, however, that Islam has emerged as a dominant marker of identity for many people in the developing world.

The significance of religious affiliation as a central component of identity is also accentuated in situations of competition and conflict among groups sharing the same territory. The ongoing sectarian conflict in Northern Ireland is an especially clear instance, but other examples abound. Catholi-

cism represented a vital element of identity for many European immigrant groups in the United States, and their struggles to preserve aspects of their language and culture were associated with and supported by the Church. The persecution of the first Mormon communities in the United States led to their increasing separation from the larger populace and heightened their sense of identity as a distinct group (Thornton 1979). Intergroup conflict in several Asian countries, including India, Malaysia, and the Philippines, appears to have heightened the significance of religion as a marker of identity in Muslim communities (Morgan et al. 2002). Where this has occurred, the rewards for conformity with perceived religious teachings on demographic and other matters were increased. Observance of religious principles reaffirmed one's sense of belonging to the community and garnered support from family, neighbors, and the broader community.

Conclusion

Although many studies have pointed to significant differences in demographic behavior between religious groups, demographers have struggled to explain why religion is a major influence on demography in some settings but not in others. Calvin Goldscheider's work over the last three decades has pointed the way toward a fuller understanding of religion's role. He has argued in favor of a broader definition of the ideological influence of religion, one that goes beyond specific rules governing such matters as contraception to include values touching on gender, sexuality, and family life. He also urged demographers to consider the importance of the status of the religious group within the social and economic order of society. The present article is an effort to extend his approach by directing attention to the role of religious institutions and to the issue of religious identity. In response to the central question of this article—when does religion influence fertility?—I have emphasized three elements. First, the religion in question must articulate behavioral norms that have linkages to fertility outcomes. Not all religions do and some groups that did so in the past have changed their rules regarding such issues as contraception and abortion. Religious norms that influence fertility may include specific directives on issues such as contraception or more general teachings related to gender roles and family life, but a full explanation of the religious effect must include a theory that links these values and norms to specific forms of demographic behavior. It must also include clear measures of the values and norms that are independent of the behavior being studied in order to avoid the trap of circular reasoning that has often plagued “value-based” explanations in demography (Davis 1963).

Second, a religious group must possess the means to communicate its teachings to its members and to enforce compliance. I have emphasized

here what Kertzer (1995: 46) has called the “coercive” powers of religion. While norms are enforced, in part, through informal social pressure, in the case of religion there has often been a formal organization in a position to provide concrete rewards, both material and symbolic, to members who conform to religious teachings and punishments to those who do not. This fact underlines the importance of examining the role of religion and religious institutions in the socio-political order.

Finally, religious groups are more likely to influence the demographic choices of their followers when members feel a strong sense of attachment to the religious community. In some settings, religious affiliation is just one of a number of memberships that persons hold and not always the most important. In other situations, however, religion is a defining trait in the lives of individuals. This is especially likely to be true when membership in a religious group is linked to a nationalist movement, or where conflict or competition with other ethno-religious groups is endemic. In these circumstances, individuals feel a greater sense of solidarity with their religious group, and this attachment raises the rewards for compliance and the penalties for deviance.

When these three attributes are present, it is very likely that religion will influence demographic behavior. Nevertheless, the consequences of the religious influence are not uniform. For example, there is a general sense that religions tend to be pronatalist and thus to encourage higher fertility. While this is probably true in most cases, it need not be so. The case of Iran is an instructive current illustration of a situation in which a highly institutionalized religion has played an important role in the spread of family planning and, ultimately, in reducing rates of fertility. This example underlines the importance of specifying the religious norms in question and their demographic consequences.

A question of great significance that this article has not addressed is the circumstances that lie behind the decline of religious influence over time. In two of the cases I have drawn on, Ireland and Quebec, the influence of religion has waned sharply in the last generation. Indeed, in the case of Quebec, which is now marked not only by very low fertility but also by high levels of cohabitation and nonmarital births, collapse would be a more accurate description. Religious institutions, with their concern for transcendent values, may be especially prone to assume the characteristics of what Lewis Coser (1974) referred to as “greedy institutions,” which seek to dominate all aspects of an individual’s life. But when the social and political conditions that allow churches to play a dominant role in society begin to change, religion’s influence can crumble quickly. In Quebec, for example, rising prosperity and the increasing part played by French Canadians in the political and economic institutions of both the province and the country undermined the Catholic Church’s claim to be the lead-

ing defender of French-Canadian interests. In the Republic of Ireland, independence opened the way for civic leaders and institutions to play a greater role in the life of the country. As the conflict with Great Britain receded in memory and the population became more homogeneously Catholic, the importance of the Catholic Church as a rallying point for nationalist sentiment declined. More recently, Ireland's entry into the European Union, and the remarkable increase in the Irish standard of living that followed, served to further marginalize the Catholic Church and limit its influence in Irish society. Recent events in Iran may point to a similarly reduced role for Muslim clerics in the social and political order. Religious leaders were a focal point of opposition to the Shah. But now, a generation removed from the Shah's regime, the populace may no longer be willing to cede such a high degree of social control to religious leaders. As their control over key social institutions weakens, so will their ability to guide the behavioral choices of their followers.

Notes

Earlier versions of this article were presented at the European Social Science History Meetings, Amsterdam, February 2000, and at Concordia University, September 2001. The author thanks Michael Carroll, Samuel Clark, Danielle Gauvreau, Ed Grabb, and Peter Neary for their helpful comments.

1 The Second Vatican Council brought together leaders of the Catholic faith in four sessions held between 1962 and 1965. The Council resulted in far-reaching changes in the organization and practices of the Roman Catholic Church and is widely seen as having opened the door to new attitudes and behavior among the faithful.

2 Although his discussion is not tied to religious beliefs, Seccombe (1992) addressed this issue in an analysis of fertility decline in nineteenth-century England.

3 Adongo et al. (1998) concur that traditional religion in Ghana was generally pronatalist, although they view religious leaders as having considerable flexibility to adapt beliefs to new situations.

4 I_g is a measure of fertility developed for use in the Princeton studies of the decline

of fertility in Europe (see Coale and Treadway 1986 for details). The measure, which ranges from 0 to 1, relates marital fertility in a population to the age-specific fertility rates of married Hutterite women living in North America in the period 1921–30. The Hutterite sect is believed to have the highest reliably recorded fertility schedule, which reflects, in large measure, near universal acceptance of religious norms forbidding the use of contraception and abortion. The Hutterites and similar religious sects are other examples of the influence of religion on fertility. However, their commitment to voluntary segregation makes them a special case, and one of limited relevance to other religious groups. Thus, I have chosen not to discuss these cases in this article.

5 Although I have not discussed the Polish situation here, it is worth noting that Polish fertility rates were the highest among the eastern bloc countries throughout the Soviet period and, though now below replacement, are still higher than in many other central and eastern European countries (Philipov and Kohler 1999).

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